BUSINESSPLAN

Dr. Mahsa Motlagh

Research-led Participatory Futures & Transformation Consultancy

Research-based consulting for participatory futures and transformation

Draft prepared for an application for the German start-up grant (Gründungszuschuss)

As of 27 October 2026 · English edition, version 1.0

Item	Status
Founder	Dr. Mahsa Motlagh
Business name	To be confirmed; currently a founder-led consulting identity
Start date	09.12.2026 (planned)
Business location / contact details	Stavenhagen; add address, telephone and email
Legal form	Sole proprietorship; freelance professional activity planned; tax classification to be clarified
Planning period	Year 1: 09.12.2026–08.12.2027; followed by two further operating years
Financial figures	Illustrative scenario; no confirmed actual figures or orders

The content is based on the supplied CV, the corrected CV information and the business positioning. Market and financial assumptions are identified as such. Personal details from the example template have not been adopted.

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1. Executive Summary

Dr. Mahsa Motlagh plans to establish a research-led participatory futures and transformation consultancy. She supports project and programme leaders whose work depends on stakeholder collaboration, future-facing decisions and translating complex knowledge into practical action.

The consultancy combines three services: Futures and Transformation Advisory, Participatory Lab and Experience Delivery, and Capability Building and Method Transfer. Clients can commission defined research and advisory projects, fully delivered labs, longer-term capability programmes or time-limited embedded assignments.

The founder holds a doctorate in governance and the socioeconomics of natural resources and brings experience in research, international consulting, participatory methods, serious games, professional learning and project coordination. Initial market entry focuses on universities, research consortia, public institutions and NGOs. Businesses with relevant transformation needs form an additional target group.

The business will initially operate as a founder-led consultancy without employees. Services will be delivered remotely, in hybrid formats and on site. Collaboration partners will be engaged on a project basis. Standardised toolkits, professional training programmes and licensed resources are options for later development; no revenue from these is included in the baseline forecast.

Metric, net of VAT	Operating year 1	Operating year 2	Operating year 3
Billable days	66	90	108
Average day rate	€900	€950	€1,000
Revenue	€59,400	€85,500	€108,000
Business expenses	€14,400	€18,000	€21,600
Profit before personal taxes	€45,000	€67,500	€86,400

The figures represent a transparent planning scenario, not demonstrated market demand. The Gründungszuschuss is not counted as business revenue or, in the absence of confirmed eligibility information, as a cash inflow. No grant approval, evidence of available own funds or confirmed orders has been provided for this forecast.

The planned start date is 9 December 2026, with the business based in Stavenhagen and operated as a sole proprietorship providing freelance professional services. Tax status, actual own funds, personal financial needs and insurance must be added. Fees should be substantiated through market discussions or quotations, and the monthly cash-flow forecast updated with actual payment terms. Final assessment of viability remains the responsibility of the competent expert body.

2. Dienstleistung

2.1. Angebote

The offer combines strategic advice, participatory delivery and capability building. The three service areas described in the positioning are organised below within the template's service structure.

2.1.1. Futures and Transformation Advisory

Independent research, analysis and strategic advice for organisations seeking to understand complex change, widen their future options and develop credible transformation pathways. The focus is on structured decision support under uncertainty rather than predicting individual future developments.

Potential outputs include a clearly defined question, a research brief, stakeholder and systems analysis, exploratory scenarios, options appraisal and a transformation roadmap. The methodology and scope of evidence are specified in the proposal. Future-oriented formats build on existing experience with scenarios, simulations, governance and systems thinking; no specific foresight certification is claimed.

Commissioning options include fixed-scope projects with milestones; commissioned labs including evaluation; multi-part capability programmes; and embedded interim assignments with a clearly bounded specialist remit. Line-management responsibilities will only be offered where explicitly agreed and supported by relevant expertise.

2.1.2. Participatory Lab and Experience Delivery

End-to-end development, facilitation, implementation and evaluation of co-creation processes, co-visioning labs, future scenarios, serious games, simulations and place-based experiments. Preparation and follow-up form part of the assignment and are included in the costing.

A typical process includes scoping and stakeholder analysis; process and format design; materials and an invitation strategy; delivery; evaluation and documentation. Deliverables may include a lab concept, game or simulation materials, documented findings, an evaluation report and prioritised next steps.

2.1.3. Capability Building and Method Transfer

Customised training, toolkits, facilitator development, coaching and method systems enable client teams to apply participatory and future-oriented approaches independently. Transfer is supported through exercises using participants' own cases, pilot applications and feedback.

Deliverables include a learning concept, training modules, facilitation guides, templates, method cards and transfer sessions. Scope and usage rights are agreed contractually. Coaching is limited to professional roles, methods and project contexts.

2.2. Kundennutzen

Better decision support: research and different bodies of knowledge are translated into accessible options and pathways for action.
Structured collaboration: participation objectives, roles and expectations are clarified, enabling competing objectives to be addressed explicitly.
Experiential learning: serious games and simulations make relationships, uncertainty and the consequences of decisions open to discussion.
Practical transfer: findings are documented and translated into responsibilities, pilot initiatives and next steps.

Internal capability: teams receive methods and materials they can continue using after the assignment.

2.3. Zielgruppe

Primary clients are project and programme leaders in universities, research consortia, public institutions and NGOs responsible for participation, transdisciplinary collaboration or capability development. Additional clients include businesses with sustainability-related transformation initiatives and substantial coordination needs. Purchasing decisions may sit with institute or departmental heads, consortium coordination, professional development or procurement functions.

Typical triggers include a new funding application, an approved collaborative project, conflicting stakeholder perspectives, an upcoming strategy process or the introduction of a new learning format. The consultancy prioritises clearly funded tasks with an identified client and realistic access to participants.

2.4. Alleinstellungsmerkmal

Differentiation rests on the combination of scientific methodological expertise, international stakeholder experience and practical format development. Analysis, shared experience and method transfer are offered through a single provider. This is a positioning approach; no legally exclusive or market-wide unique position is claimed.

2.5. Genehmigungen/Zulassungen

No specific sector licence is currently assumed for the planned general consulting and training services. The precise activities and any boundaries with regulated services must be checked before launch. Classification as freelance professional activity or a trade must be clarified with the tax office or a tax adviser. Legal, tax and psychotherapeutic advice are outside the offer.

3. Gründerperson

Dr. Mahsa Motlagh holds a Dr. agr. from the University of Bonn (11/2012–01/2018), a master's degree in Agricultural Sciences & Sustainable Resource Management (04/2009–09/2012), and a bachelor's degree in Agricultural Economics & Development from the University of Tehran (1999–2003).

Period	Experience and relevance to the business
04/2023–03/2026	University of Kassel, Kassel Institute for Sustainability: programme and methodology development, Living Labs, serious games and interdisciplinary collaboration.
07/2021–03/2023	International consulting and business development in sustainability, transformation and learning.
07/2019–06/2021	Bonn Alliance: Digitainable project, participatory assessment frameworks, stakeholder workshops and professional learning.
02/2017–06/2019	TH Köln: international research coordination, blended learning, governance and diplomacy.
06/2015–11/2015	ENTRO, Addis Ababa: field research, interviews, stakeholder workshops and multi-party dialogue.

Selected assignments and networks include NIRAS, the Global Council for Science and the Environment, adelphi, ARSINOE, SPARKLE, TransformERS and ITD Alliance. These CV entries demonstrate experience and contacts, but do not constitute current client contracts, binding recommendations or revenue guarantees for the new business.

The combination of consulting, project management, international collaboration and format development supports the proposed services. Publications on serious games (2025) and the Digitalization Sustainability Matrix (2020) demonstrate methodological engagement. Professional development includes Agile Scrum, facilitation, coaching, evaluation and Water Diplomacy; no separate PRINCE2 certification is claimed.

Languages according to the CV: native Farsi, professional English, intermediate German, and basic Arabic and Turkish. English-language assignments offer a suitable entry point; project-specific support and quality assurance should be planned for linguistically or legally demanding German procedures.

Areas still to develop or substantiate include systematic client acquisition, financial management, contracting and structured price validation. Dedicated working time, start-up advice and tax support are planned for these tasks. The current professional situation since April 2026 and eligibility status for funding remain to be added.

4. Marktanalyse

4.1. Aktuelle Marktsituation/Trends

The business addresses interface challenges between research, policy, organisations and practice: complex information, divergent interests and decisions under uncertainty. Demand for participation, knowledge transfer and organisational learning is a business hypothesis derived from professional experience. It is not treated as evidence of a quantified market size or secured demand.

Research and publicly funded projects may offer suitable assignments, but are subject to budget approval, funding conditions and procurement procedures. Businesses may decide more quickly but expect clear benefits and demonstrable results. Assignment sizes and sales cycles need to be tested for each client segment.

4.2. Wettbewerbsanalyse

Provider type	Typical focus	Own approach
Foresight / strategy consultancies	Analysis, future visions, strategic options	Integration with participation and practical learning formats
Facilitation and organisational consultancies	Group processes and change support	Research-based methods and integration of complex knowledge
Serious-game / training providers	Learning products and delivery	Custom process design, evaluation and transfer
Research institutes / universities	Specialist research and project-based participation	Defined support service available for external commissioning

The overview is a qualitative segmentation, not a survey of individual competitors. Comparable providers, fees, scope and procurement routes should be substantiated before submission through specific quotations or documented discussions. No blanket superiority over other providers is assumed.

4.3. Zielgruppenanalyse

Market entry prioritises three segments: research consortia with participation tasks; public and non-profit programme organisations facing transformation questions; and organisations requiring method and facilitator development. A small, addressable client base with a concrete budget is more relevant to a sole consultancy than an unsubstantiated total market estimate.

4.4. Einschätzung des eigenen Marktpotenzials

Validation plan: initially ten structured needs-assessment discussions and three written proposals or pilot concepts. These should test budgets, decision-making roles, procurement timelines, actual problems and willingness to pay. These activities are targets, not completed discussions. The financial scenario assumes 66 billable days in the first operating year; their feasibility must be supported by the sales pipeline.

5. Marketing

5.1. Produktpolitik

The three service areas are offered as clearly defined modules. A limited diagnostic assignment may lead to a lab and subsequently to a transfer programme. Each proposal specifies the initial question, deliverables, client contributions, dates, evaluation criteria and usage rights. Standardisation follows repeated application; licensing revenue is excluded from the baseline scenario.

5.2. Preispolitik

Operating year 1 uses an illustrative net fee of €900 per billable working day. This rate is a costing assumption to be validated, not a statement based on surveyed market prices. It also supports non-billable sales and administrative time. Fixed-price projects transparently account for preparation, delivery, evaluation and a contingency allowance.

Illustrative service	Effort	Planned price, net
Research / advisory sprint	5 days	€4,500
Custom lab including preparation and follow-up	8 days	€7,200
Training and transfer programme	10 days	€9,000
Embedded specialist assignment	As agreed in days	€900 per day

Travel, venues, catering, external co-facilitation and special materials are agreed separately. Pass-through client costs are excluded from the revenue example. Any additional business-borne costs require the project margin to be recalculated. VAT will be handled according to the actual tax status; all planned prices are net of VAT.

5.3. Kommunikations- und Vertriebspolitik

Market entry uses professional contacts from previous projects, targeted personal outreach, referrals and a professional online presence. Examples of methods and results are published only with the necessary permission. Case studies must not imply existing client relationships or reference permissions that have not been obtained.

Sales process: needs assessment → qualification of budget and decision authority → defined proposal → written commission → delivery and evaluation → transfer or follow-on offer. Advance or milestone payments should be sought for longer projects, but apply only if agreed contractually.

Monthly indicators include qualified contacts, proposals, conversion rate, contracted backlog, billable days and cash actually received. The start-up target is four qualified discussions and two proposals per month. In the medium term, an individual client should ideally account for no more than 40% of revenue; this is a risk-management target, not a current actual figure.

6. Unternehmen und Organisation

6.1. Rechtsform und Eigentumsverhältnisse

A sole proprietorship wholly owned by Dr. Mahsa Motlagh is planned, with freelance professional activity commencing on 9 December 2026. Classification as freelance scientific, advisory or teaching activity has not yet been confirmed. If trade activities predominate or are added, registration and tax implications must be checked. Existing full-time self-employment or a business launch that has already taken place are not assumed.

6.2. Organisation

The founder is responsible for scoping, methodology, delivery, quality assurance and client relations. External support for bookkeeping and tax matters will be used as needed. A simple project and financial overview records capacity, commitments, proposals, invoices and cash receipts.

Capacity planning assumes 200 available working days per operating year. In year 1, 66 days are billable (33%). The remainder covers client acquisition, proposal development, administration, professional learning, networking and contingency time. The days quoted in proposals include all agreed billable preparation and follow-up days; these are not counted twice.

Contracts cover scope, acceptance, fees, payment terms, cancellation, confidentiality, liability and rights to materials. Background methods and client-specific outputs are distinguished. Embedded assignments must be genuinely structured as independent work, with employment-status clarification considered where appropriate.

Personal data from research, workshops and participants are processed for specified purposes. Appropriate privacy information, legal bases, data-processing agreements where required, access protection and deletion schedules are necessary. Professional or financial-loss liability insurance should be assessed against the actual service profile. Quality is supported through documented objectives, piloting, feedback and comparison of results with agreed goals.

6.3. Personal

No employees are included in the baseline scenario for the first three years. Independent partners may support larger labs. Their costs must be calculated before proposals are submitted and agreed with clients. Permanent capacity expansion will only follow a secured order pipeline.

6.4. Standort

The business will be based in Stavenhagen; the precise business address remains to be added. A lean digital operation is planned, preferably using existing work infrastructure without a long-term external office lease. Permitted use must be checked for the specific premises. Meetings take place remotely or at suitable client or event venues.

7. Finanzplanung und Finanzierung

All figures below form an independently developed illustrative scenario. They do not replace personal budget information or evidence of own funds, quoted prices or orders. Operating year 1 runs from 09.12.2026 to 08.12.2027, year 2 from 09.12.2027 to 08.12.2028, and year 3 from 09.12.2028 to 08.12.2029. Monthly planning uses twelve operating months from launch, not calendar years.

Service area	Days, year 1	Days, year 2	Days, year 3
Futures and Transformation Advisory	24	32	36
Participatory Lab and Experience Delivery	24	34	42
Capability Building and Method Transfer	18	24	30
Total	66	90	108

One possible first-year assignment mix would be four six-day advisory sprints, three eight-day labs and three six-day transfer programmes. This represents ten project commissions, not necessarily ten different clients. No confirmed bookings are available for this forecast. Years 2 and 3 assume both greater utilisation and an average day rate increasing to €950 and €1,000 respectively.

Cost item, net / year	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Software, IT, data, communication	2400	2700	3000
Marketing, networking and sales	2400	3000	3600
Tax advice, bookkeeping and legal support	2400	3000	3600
Business insurance	1200	1500	1800
Business-borne travel / venue costs	2400	3600	4800
Professional development, materials and other costs	3600	4200	4800
Total business expenses	14400	18000	21600

Personal health and long-term care insurance, income tax and living expenses are not business expenses in this table. Separately reimbursed client project costs are excluded from both costs and revenue. Major investments, depreciation and subsequent VAT treatment must be added once specified; the annual overview is a simplified surplus forecast, not a balance sheet.

Results overview: year 1: €59,400 revenue − €14,400 expenses = €45,000. Year 2: €85,500 − €18,000 = €67,500. Year 3: €108,000 − €21,600 = €86,400. All results are before personal taxes; see also the Executive Summary table.

One-off allocation / reserve	Illustrative amount
IT / work equipment, conservatively treated as an initial cash outflow	€2,000
Setup, advice, business presence and start-up costs	€1,000
Available opening business cash after start-up payments	€20,000
Total assumed financing requirement	€23,000

Own funds of €23,000 are assumed solely for calculation purposes. Their actual availability is unconfirmed and must be evidenced or replaced by realistic alternative financing. No external financing is treated as committed. The Gründungszuschuss is excluded from the scenario.

Personal needs are illustrated at €1,800 for living expenses and €600 for personal health and long-term care insurance per month, totalling €2,400. Actual requirements may differ substantially. A flat tax reserve of 25% of cumulative positive operating profit is treated as restricted cash; this is not an individual tax calculation. Simplifying assumption: invoicing and payment occur in the same month, with monthly business expenses of €1,200. Delayed receipts are considered in the risk scenario.

Month	Receipts	Business costs	Personal incl. health cover	Tax reserve[1]	Cash balance
1	€0	€1,200	€2,400	€0	€16,400
2	€0	€1,200	€2,400	€0	€12,800
3	€1,800	€1,200	€2,400	€0	€11,000
4	€2,700	€1,200	€2,400	€0	€10,100
5	€3,600	€1,200	€2,400	€525	€9,575
6	€4,500	€1,200	€2,400	€825	€9,650
7	€5,400	€1,200	€2,400	€1,050	€10,400
8	€6,300	€1,200	€2,400	€1,275	€11,825
9	€7,200	€1,200	€2,400	€1,500	€13,925
10	€8,100	€1,200	€2,400	€1,725	€16,700
11	€9,000	€1,200	€2,400	€1,950	€20,150
12	€10,800	€1,200	€2,400	€2,400	€24,950

[1] Monthly allocation to the tax reserve. Opening cash: €20,000. Lowest balance: €9,575. Closing balance: €24,950. Annual personal needs total €28,800; the tax reserve totals €11,250. Start-up payments of €3,000 have already been deducted before month 1. All amounts exclude VAT; separate VAT cash-flow planning must be added once tax status is clarified.

In the baseline scenario, annual profit of €45,000 leaves €33,750 available for owner drawings after a flat tax reserve of €11,250. After personal needs of €28,800, €4,950 remains. This is calculated coverage under the stated assumptions, not confirmed economic viability.

At €900 per day and annual costs of €14,400, 16 billable days cover business costs only. To fund personal needs of €28,800 after a 25% tax reserve would require at least 59 days or annual revenue of €53,100. Unexpected expenses, retirement provision and actual tax and insurance payments may increase this requirement.

Scenario, year 1	Revenue	Profit	After 25% reserve and personal needs
Baseline: 66 days × €900	€59,400	€45,000	€4,950
Lower utilisation: 50 days × €900	€45,000	€30,600	€-5,850
Fee −10%: 66 days × €810	€53,460	€39,060	€495

Lower utilisation would create an annual shortfall of €5,850 in the personal-needs coverage model. If every client payment is delayed by one month with costs and personal needs unchanged, the lowest first-year cash balance falls to €5,000; the year-end balance is €14,150 after retaining the annual tax reserve of €11,250. A receivable of €10,800 from month 12 would then be collected in month 13. Actual tax payment dates and payment terms require separate planning.

> Long procurement and sales cycles: address several client segments, build the pipeline early and avoid reserving capacity without a written commission.

Dependence on individual clients or funded projects: use smaller entry offers, work with multiple clients and review revenue concentration regularly.
Illness or overload: allow contingency days, define clear service boundaries and build a qualified partner network.
Unpaid preparation or unclear usage rights: document scope and changes in writing; agree separately on materials and rights.
Insufficient own funds or higher personal needs: secure financing before launch, adjust drawings realistically and recalculate cash flow.

Before the planned start on 9 December 2026 in Stavenhagen: clarify funding eligibility and status; substantiate actual personal needs, insurance and own funds. Months 1–2: service descriptions, contract foundations, ten needs-assessment discussions and initial proposals. Months 3–6: first paid pilots, evaluation and pricing review. Months 7–12: repeat clients, documented transfer offers and monthly budget-to-actual review. Standardisation or licensing only follows validated demand.

Planned start: 9 December 2026; location: Stavenhagen. Add complete contact details, the business address and professional status since April 2026.
Confirm legal form, tax classification and VAT treatment.
Provide actual own funds and any written financing commitments; replace or confirm the illustrative assumption of €23,000.
Prepare a personal household budget including housing, insurance, retirement provision, maintenance obligations and existing liabilities.
Provide documented needs-assessment discussions, comparable prices, proposals, letters of intent or orders, where actually available.
Obtain quotations for insurance, software, tax advice, equipment and premises if required.
Update monthly cash-flow planning with actual payment terms, taxes and any approved Gründungszuschuss.
Attach the CV, degree and training certificates, and approved work samples or references.

Content sources: the supplied original CV, “CV_No Name.pdf”; the corrected English CV text of 27 October 2026; and the client-provided “Business Positioning”. Structural template: “Businessplan_Max-Muster.docx”. The template is used solely for its structure; the example business's name, location, financial figures, start date and characteristics have not been adopted.

For this plan, network roles marked “Now” in the CV are understood as ongoing experience according to the supplied information. Their current scope and any contractual commitments must be confirmed before submission. Publications under review are not treated as already published evidence.

No external market studies, current competitor prices or binding funding decisions have been researched. Market assumptions are therefore explicitly presented as hypotheses to be validated. All financial figures are model assumptions; neither funding nor business success is guaranteed.

Place / date: _____

Dr. Mahsa Motlagh: _____